

Chapter 110-5

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Before taking Liang Wanwan back to school, Liang Shi first brought her to Liang Xinzhou's place.

When Liang Xinzhou saw his two younger sisters, his expression remained indifferent as always. He only asked about their daily affairs, mostly about their studies and health, reminding them to eat properly and such. After finishing the routine questions, he finally asked Liang Wanwan: "What exactly happened last night?"

At the mention of last night, Liang Wanwan's heart felt like it was bleeding, but she still told Liang Xinzhou everything.

After finishing, she asked cautiously: "Da-ge, I didn't cause you any trouble, did I?"

Because Liang Xinzhou was the eldest brother and much older than them.

Many things were shouldered by Liang Xinzhou at the front. Sometimes when Liang Wanwan did something wrong, Qiu Zimin would even complain to Liang Xinzhou about it.

Let alone this time.

Because first there was Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe collectively leaving home, and then she had directly slapped Liang Xinran.

Qiu Zimin would definitely be furious and call to scold Liang Xinzhou. She might even falsely accuse Liang Xinzhou of instigating the younger siblings.

Liang Xinzhou curved his lips into a smile, carrying a hint of mockery, but quickly restrained it.

He said flatly: "What trouble could you cause me? I didn't answer their calls."

He hadn't argued or defended Liang Wanwan either.

What's done is done. Was he supposed to make Liang Wanwan stand there and let Liang Xinran slap her back?

That was impossible.

Because of one Liang Xinran, after hitting two sons, they were going to hit the youngest daughter too?

That would truly be a joke.

Liang Xinzhou would never let such a thing happen no matter what.

For something to make Liang Wanwan angry enough to hit someone, she must have been absolutely livid. That slap—Liang Xinran deserved it.

When Liang Xinran had first returned, Liang Xinzhou still had a sliver of warmth toward her. He thought that if she had good character, she could be raised at home, or they could give her a large sum of money and have her live elsewhere.

The whole family shouldn't fall apart because of her return. After all, by blood, she was still his biological sister.

But that was just a tiny bit of warmth within his wariness, which couldn't withstand her causing trouble again and again.

The moment Liang Xinzhou moved out of the house, he knew that if they didn't send Liang Xinran away, the family's collapse was inevitable.

So he might as well go all in.¹

He had come out with this mindset, though he had forgotten about his younger siblings.

Looking at all these conflicts happening in their family, calling them coincidences seemed far too coincidental.

And Liang Xinzhou had never believed in such coincidences.

Liang Shi then asked how things were going with Xu Tong's side and whether there were any new leads.

Liang Xinzhou hesitated for a moment, then brought down a stack of documents from the study upstairs. These were materials he had traced and uncovered yesterday.

He had discovered that Xu Tong's father, Xu Kang, had once been in contact with a woman named Zhang Yangning, and this woman was from Taozhi Village—the same place as Liang Xinran.

Zhang Yangning was an HR at an advertising company, five years older than Liang Xinran, and had graduated from an ordinary second-tier university.²

But for Taozhi Village, this was quite an impressive accomplishment. However, both her parents had passed away, and she had also been raised by her grandmother, who had long since passed as well. She was essentially alone in the world with no ties left in Taozhi Village, yet she would return to the village two or three times a year.

Liang Xinzhou had someone call the village chief of Taozhi Village. According to him, Zhang Yangning was much older than Liang Xinran, and he hadn't heard of any interaction between the two. Moreover, back then, Zhang Yangning's mother and Liang Xinran's mother were famously at odds, and because of that, the children from both families didn't speak to each other either.

Furthermore, Zhang Yangning was known in the village for being arrogant—probably because she was one of the few college graduates from the village. Every year when she came home, she drove a new car, dressed immaculately, and as soon as she arrived, she would hole up in her renovated house and basically never go out.

She would stay in the village for a few days during New Year and then leave, never even greeting the neighbors.

At the end, the village chief even complained that he didn't know why she came back every year—she didn't even know to bring flowers when visiting her parents' graves.

Liang Shi quickly skimmed through the documents. They contained Xu Kang's resume. His previous company was also a design firm in the industry, but not very well-known—far inferior to Haiwei. However, the fact that any company would hire him after he had stolen company secrets was already quite remarkable.

But the reason he only worked at the second company for one month was that the company belatedly discovered the real reason he had left Haiwei, so they fired him.

Because he had stolen company secrets, he had to compensate Haiwei Jewelry 1.2 million yuan.

For him, that was an enormous sum. And according to what Liang Xinzhou knew, the secret he sold had only fetched one million.

After everything, he was actually out 200,000 yuan.

It was also because he had worked at Haiwei Jewelry for quite a long time that the company showed him some mercy and didn't take him to court or have him imprisoned.

But this incident had dealt Xu Kang a significant blow and turned his life upside down.

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1. "破釜沉舟" (pò fǔ chén zhōu) is a Chinese idiom meaning "to break the cauldrons and sink the boats"—referring to the historical story of a general who ordered his troops to destroy their cooking pots and boats after crossing a river, leaving no option for retreat. It means to be determined to succeed by eliminating all means of retreat; to go all in or burn one's bridges. ⇐
 2. "二本" (èr běn, second-tier) refers to China's university ranking system. Universities are categorized into tiers, with "一本" (first-tier) being the most prestigious and "二本" (second-tier) being less selective but still respectable institutions. ⇐